

MUSIC

BRINGING RAP HOME AGAIN

It got everyone from Virat Kohli to Nargis Fakhri excited, but did **MTV Hustle 2.0** *create any real rap stars?*



When 23-year-old Srushti Tawade decided to participate in *MTV Hustle 2.0*, the second season of the country's first hip-hop reality show, she hadn't contended with the fact that the show would turn her into an overnight sensation. A completely self-taught rapper, Tawade caught everyone's attention on the show with the now-viral 'Chill Kinda Guy', in which she rapped about religious fanaticism. There was also 'Bachpan', a biting track in which Tawade confronted her thorny childhood memory of domestic violence. The spunky lyrics belie the social commentary that Tawade, one of the three female contestants, brought to both these songs. And even though Tawade didn't eventually end up lifting the trophy, her distinct voice left an indelible impression on hip-hop fans around the country.

Still, the spotlight wouldn't have come this easy for Tawade had it not been for *MTV Hustle 2.0*. Hosted by Krissann Barretto and judged by Badshah (and four squad bosses), the new season of the reality show uncovered a range of diverse talents, whether it is winner MC Square's unique storytelling or runner-up Paradox's keen ear for rhyme. Importantly, the accessible format of the show followed the foundation laid by Zoya Akhtar's immensely successful *Gully Boy* (2019). *Hustle*, too, took it upon itself to bring the hip-hop genre into Indian living rooms.

For music writer Arunima Joshua, this transition didn't seem that surprising. "Hip-hop is probably the most mainstream massy non-Indian genre right now in the country. It was inevitable that it would acquire such a national